



Trails to You



Spring 2009

DCNR Survey Investigates Trail Gaps

A recent DCNR funded study conducted by Penn State University (PSU) sheds new light on gaps in the statewide trail network and reveals attitudes that will help shape trail building strategies and funding policies over the next five years.

Beginning in September 2008, DCNR and PSU began collecting detailed descriptions of critical gaps, disconnections and areas devoid of footpaths, right-of-ways, and off-road vehicle tracks in Pennsylvania's rapidly growing network of trails. Twenty-one major trail organizations statewide were asked to submit descriptions of their top ten priority trail gaps. There were 107 gaps identified in 41 counties. Each gap was mapped using DCNR's geographic information system so that details about the trail gap could be analyzed in relation to its specific location and its proximity to other trails and nearby population centers.

Survey Polls Statewide Organizations

In addition to identifying physical locations of major trail gaps, researchers assessed location-based priorities, social factors and organizational barriers to filling the gaps. Two hundred seventy-six "expert" advocates from trail clubs and affiliate organizations voiced their opinions on key issues and priorities related to trail development.

Most of the survey participants considered acquisition of trail right-of-ways to be highly important, especially in areas where the opportunity for a

trail might soon be lost to urban or suburban development. At the same time, many participants felt that it was highly important to take full advantage of landowners' willingness to allow trail development near or within their properties.

Trails Valued for Outstanding Natural Scenery and Multiple Uses

Closing a gap on an existing trail or providing connections between trails projects were among the highest priorities compared to 8 other factors in the "geographic issues" category. Among other issues of high importance in the "social/experiential" category were access to outstanding natural scenery and trails that accommodate more than one user group.

Pennsylvania's abundance of greenways and trails provide numerous opportunities for scenic recreational experiences. There are 97 rail-trails totaling 1,350 miles and more than a dozen major hiking trails longer than 50 miles, including 230 miles of the best-known long distance hiking trail in the nation – the Appalachian National Scenic Trail.

Plan for Action

The trail gap research project was conducted as a component of the Statewide Comprehensive Outdoor Recreation Plan, 2009-2013 (SCORP). The SCORP is updated every five years to provide statewide policy direction and maintain the state's eligibility to receive federal Land and Water Conservation Fund dollars.



The trail gap study was one of 4 research projects conducted to support recommendations in the SCORP. The other surveys included a resident survey of resource needs, a state park visitor survey, and facilitated discussion groups consisting of urban youth and adults age 48 to 72 (Baby Boomers). Survey methods included paper/mail and internet questionnaires. Overall, the research effort collected input from more than 13,000 citizens and civic leaders. The SCORP will contain key recommendations focused on four major themes:

- Aligning State Planning Efforts for Recreation
- Defining the Role of Recreation in Health, Quality of Life and the Economy
- Reconnecting People to the Natural Environment and Stewardship
- Developing a Statewide Trail Network

The plan is scheduled to be released in late summer 2009. More information on the updated Recreation Plan is available on the web at www.PAOutdoorRecPlan.net.

American Trails Announces 2008 State Trail Award Winners

Just as our last edition was going to print, American Trails was hosting the 19th National Trails Symposium in Little Rock, Arkansas. As part of this event, state level awards were announced in several categories. Ron Steffey and Jim Holden were recognized with the Trail Advocate and Trail Worker Awards. In addition to their local work, which is highlighted below, Ron and Jim regularly share their expertise with others in the trails community through contributions to this newsletter and other publications and presentations at the Summit and other workshops around the state. Congratulations to Ron and Jim for these well-deserved awards.



2008 STATE TRAIL ADVOCACY AWARD WINNERS

PENNSYLVANIA: Ron Steffey

Ron Steffey is Executive Director of the Allegheny Valley Land Trust, whose mission is to “protect and convert railroad corridors into trails for public use, thereby providing opportunities for commuters and outdoor recreational activities. Our projects will maintain the integrity of these corridors for future transportation use while acting as an economic stimulus for the area communities.”

A few years ago, Ron was using the Armstrong Trail a lot, while he was on Workmen's Compensation and trying to heal his foot injury from working in the coal mines. After a number of complaints to a trail volunteer about how the trail was being built, Ron was invited to get involved and fix it. He started out as an Americorps position with the Allegheny Valley Land Trust, and is now their full-time Executive Director. Ron has been working tirelessly to build public awareness and support for the Armstrong Trail and to initiate other nearby rail-trail projects. Ron has also been a leader in advocating for the formation of the Erie to Pittsburgh Trail, of which the Armstrong Trail would be one segment.

Reminder: RTCA Program Now Accepting Applications

The National Park Service helps partners plan successful locally-led outdoor recreation and natural resource conservation projects. August 1 is the deadline for the next round of assistance from our Rivers, Trails, and Conservation Assistance (RTCA) Program. Visit www.nps.gov/rtca for more information.

You can see Jim Holden's write-up on page 10.

In this issue

- * KTA to Host 25-mile Hiking/Trail Runner Challenge
- * Health Benefits of Outdoor Recreation
- * 2009 PA Greenways & Trails Summit
- * Online Interactive Three Rivers Heritage Trail Map
- * Groundbreaking Ceremony for Scranton Riverwalk
- * Progress on Water Trails
- * Carlisle's Rail-with-Trail Concept
- * Maintenance Column
- * Much More

Over 130 Attend The Trail Towns Conference

Trails can provide an economic boon to the communities they pass through. In March, the Schuylkill River Heritage Area, in Pottstown, hosted a Trail Towns Conference that examined how the Schuylkill River Trail's growing popularity can help revitalize surrounding municipalities. More than 130 representatives from various businesses, governments and organizations attended.

The conference, over a year in the planning, was an overwhelming success. Speakers included an impressive slate of 12 experts who presented ideas for business and community initiatives to help stimulate economic growth in towns all along the trail.

The keynote address was given by Cathy McCollom, regional director of The Progress Fund's Trail Town Program, which has

successfully promoted business development along the 150-mile Great Allegheny Trail.

While all trails can help stimulate local economies, the Schuylkill River Trail is particularly promising in this regard because of its length, which, when complete, will total over 130 miles. Studies show that the longer a trail is the farther people will travel to use it. And, people who come from out of town will spend four times as much as local users. Those who stay overnight will spend even more.

At the conference, a promotional film about the Schuylkill River Trail was debuted, and discussions focused on the needs of area businesses, the role of local governments and the importance of hospitality training.

As a result of the conference, Heritage Area staff members hope to put together a short presentation that they can offer to municipalities and agencies in the future. Such presentations are expected to encourage others to join the effort to build on the trail's economic potential.

Funding for the workshop came from the William Penn Foundation, Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources, Greater Philadelphia Tourism and Marketing Corporation and Wallace, Roberts and Todd.

Trail Town Program Focuses on Business Development in Trail Communities

The Trail Town Program, an economic development initiative along the Great Allegheny Passage, works with trail communities and businesses to realize the economic potential of trail-based tourism. In partnership with Laurel Highlands Visitors Bureau and the Allegheny Trail Alliance, the program recently completed a season-long trail user survey and analysis. The report can be found at www.trailtowns.org, where site visitors will also find a listing of available trip packages and bike rides. The list is posted as a convenience to trail users planning their trips

and to highlight businesses that cater to the trail audience. This is one of various tactics the Trail Town Program and its partners take to assist trail businesses and communities in reaching the trail market. Other notable efforts include working with communities in marketing available commercial properties, as well as a new three year partnership with the Student Conservation Association, the Trail Town Outreach Program. A five person corps of college graduates is helping to carry out the mission of the Trail Town Program and that of the SCA. Two

of the Corp's major projects in the first year include offering energy assessments to businesses and expanding the Great Allegheny Passage's social media presence via Facebook and Twitter.

To learn more about the Trail Town Program, a project of The Progress Fund, visit www.trailtowns.org, or call Cathy McCollom at (724) 216-9160.

ONLINE INTERACTIVE THREE RIVERS HERITAGE TRAIL MAP

Friends of the Riverfront is proud to announce the launch of the Three Rivers Heritage Trail Interactive Map. In response to the popularity of the print trail map and guide, Friends of the Riverfront commissioned an online version which is running live now at Friends of the Riverfront's website at <http://www.friendsoftheriverfront.org/map>. The interactive version of the map holds a much greater capacity for listing trailside amenities and points of interest proximal to where the Heritage Trail runs than does the paper map. This Interactive map is the first adaptation of interactive mapping technology applied for trail use, and will extend the reach of the trail and its recommended amenities to new users as well as visitors to the city.

There are currently over 200 points of interest categorized on the online map with integrated features such as zoom, click and

drag, printing isolated sections, saving favorite locations/destinations, contact information for all points of interest, as well as the ability to turn on and off all features of the map legend for ease-of-use. With over 17,000 unique visitors to the Friends of the Riverfront website last year, we are anticipating an increase in visitors due to added efficiency the online map makes available to the thousands that currently utilize its' service.

The Three Rivers Heritage Trail is a paved and dedicated biking, hiking, and walking trail around Pittsburgh. Running for over 21 miles along both sides of the Allegheny, Monongahela and Ohio Rivers, it is an almost complete public route for cyclists, walkers, runners, and in some places rollerbladers. With funding from foundations, governments, corporations, individuals and through intense collaboration with community partners,

government officials, and diverse volunteer base, our rivers and riverfronts have been transformed from industrial wastelands to international examples of environmental renewal. Annually, over 2 million people utilize the Three Rivers Heritage Trail which is promoted in our free Heritage Trail Map with distribution to approximately 50,000 individuals at several hundred locations within the city and surrounding areas.

Friends of the Riverfront co-partnered with the Southern-California based web design company Juxtaflo and Pittsburgh-based Bally Design to create and design the map and have arranged to establish an online Interactive Map, the first of its kind. Support for the initiative was made possible by The Buhl Foundation, Allegheny County, Steel Industry Heritage Corporation and Visit Pittsburgh.

"Welcome to PA" Highlands Trail Celebration A Great Success:

On Saturday, May 16th with over a hundred in attendance, AMC, the NY-NJ Trail Conference and the Borough of Riegelsville celebrated the near completion of the 150-mile Highlands Trail in NJ and NY and welcomed the Highlands Trail into Riegelsville, Pennsylvania. The celebration began on the NJ side of the Riegelsville Toll-Supported Bridge with speeches given by the NYNJTC and Delaware River Joint Toll Bridge Commission. The celebration continued with a hike across the bridge welcoming the Highlands Trail into PA. This included a ribbon-cutting on the NJ/PA border in the middle of the Delaware River on the bridge. Speeches followed on the PA side adjacent to The Riegelsville Inn by the Borough of Riegelsville, AMC, Rep. Marguerite Quinn, and Diane Kripas, DCNR. A special unveiling of the Welcome to Riegelsville/Highlands Trail sign proceeded officially marking the beginning of the Highlands Trail in PA. The celebration finished with refreshments and a silent auction at the Borough Park including hikes at Mariton Wildlife Sanctuary and paddling demonstrations on the Delaware River. AMC also unveiled Hike the Highlands cards that AMC has done in partnership with Wildlands Conservancy. The cards feature 22 hikes throughout the 13-county PA Highlands. A big thank you to AMC volunteers, speakers, local retailers, and supporters for making the celebration a success!

You can read more details and view pictures of the celebration and the PA Highlands Trail Network by following our blog at www.outdoors.org/hikethehighlands. On this webpage you can also download individual PA Hike the Highlands cards.

KTA TO HOST 25-MILE HIKING/TRAIL RUNNER CHALLENGE EVENT IN SUSQUEHANNA GORGE

Hikers and trail runners from the Northeast will have a chance to test their endurance and strength of will on the scenic rolling hills of the lower Susquehanna Gorge September 12 when the Keystone Trails Association hosts the 25-mile Susquehanna Super Hike in York and Lancaster counties.

"The daunting hike on the Mason-Dixon and Conestoga Trails alternates breathtaking vistas with steep descents into dark, scenic hollows followed by strenuous climbs to the next vista," said KTA President Thyra Sperry. "Prepare yourself for the steep hills, rocky terrain and deep ravines of the Susquehanna Super Hike, an arduous, undulating and challenging course"

The event course will traverse both sides of the Susquehanna River in York and Lancaster counties. Hikers and trail runners

will begin at the York Hiking Club clubhouse near the Otter Creek Campground and end at the Pequea Campground.

"At least eleven significant climbs with 4,203 feet elevation gain and 4,191 feet elevation loss for a total elevation change of 8,394 feet are encountered along the route," said Event Coordinator Paul Shaw.

Just a few of the highlights include Urey Overlook, historic Lock 12, crossing the Susquehanna River on the Norman Wood Bridge, Face Rock Overlook, Kelly's Run, the Pinnacle Overlook and Wind Cave. In this timed event, participants are required, for safety reasons, to reach each checkpoint within a certain time period and to complete the hike in no more than 12.5 hours.

The registration fee is \$50 for participants registering on or before August 22 and includes bus transportation to the starting point, snacks and beverages at several checkpoints along the route, a picnic dinner at the finish, a one-year membership to KTA and a t-shirt. After August 22, the registration fee is \$65; on-site registration is \$80. To register visit www.kta-hike.org.

*Have an event that
you'd like us to include
in a future newsletter?
Please email the
details to*

*info@
greendiamondtrails.
com*

Ride the Trail to a Cure

In 2006 The Grey Mare Society (our group of ladies over 50 who ride together) decided to combine a fall trail ride with raising funds to fight breast cancer. We thought that rather than riding for a national organization, we would support organizations that directly help the breast cancer victims in our area. So we organized a trail ride to benefit The Pennsylvania Breast Cancer Coalition and Breast Cancer Awareness - Cumberland Valley.

The fourth annual Grey Mare Society Ride the Trail to a Cure will be Saturday, September 26, 2009. This is a 3 to 4 hour ride on wide trails through the Michaux forest. Enjoy a delicious hot lunch after the ride. For information on this ride or other Ride the Trail to a Cure Rides, please visit <http://www.ridethetrailtoacure.org/>. Supported by the Pennsylvania Equine Council.

Interpretive Master Plan Reveals Tremendous Heritage & Tourism Potential

The Susquehanna Greenway links the multitude of recreational, historic, environmental, and cultural assets along the Susquehanna River's nearly 500 miles and 22 counties in Pennsylvania. The Susquehanna Greenway Partnership (SGP) is a nonprofit organization dedicated to developing and sustaining the Susquehanna Greenway to connect communities and enrich lives through enhanced recreation, healthy living, economic prosperity and environmental stewardship. SGP recently completed the Susquehanna River Water Trail and Greenway Interpretive Master Plan to heighten the public's awareness of these river corridor-based assets while accentuating their collective relationship through the Susquehanna Greenway. Findings and recommendations of the plan were presented to over 140 attendees of the Susquehanna Greenway Symposium on March 24. The event was sponsored by the Chesapeake Bay Commission.

The plan emphasizes the natural, cultural and stewardship components throughout the Susquehanna Greenway network corridor and along the Susquehanna River Water Trail. The plan evaluated over 100 assets and begins to organize these through an implementation and operations matrix, and an outdoor recreation and linkage system. Recommendations outline the development of interpretive media (signs, online tour guides, brochures, podcasts, etc.) that link together resources and attractions under the Susquehanna Greenway brand.

"The basic intent of this interpretive plan is to: highlight the interpretive 'gems' throughout the Susquehanna Greenway; provide an 'experience of place'; and create an awareness of the interconnection between these assets and the Chesapeake Bay," said Gary Bloss, SGP Executive Director. "We want visitors and residents to discover and



explore the Greenway: the historic downtowns and natural areas it encompasses; the trails, bike paths, cultural assets, and recreation it offers. And we want them to remember 'Susquehanna Greenway' as a destination in and of itself. The interpretive plan is step one in achieving that objective and in helping to build the partnerships vital to its creation."

Funding to develop the plan was provided by the National Park Service's Chesapeake Bay Gateway Network and the PA Department of Conservation and Natural Resources. More information on the Interpretive Master Plan and the Susquehanna Greenway Symposium can be found at www.susquehannagreenway.org.

County will Support Carlisle's Rail-with-Trail Concept

By Jason Scott, Sentinel Reporter, Carlisle Sentinel, February 23, 2009

Cumberland County commissioners will follow Carlisle Borough Council's lead in drafting a letter of support for a rail-with-trail project in Carlisle. On Thursday, the board listened to the proposal from Chris Houston, chairman of the LeTort Regional Authority, and Nick Stamos, Dickinson College's vice president for campus operations. The college and LRA are hoping to develop a three-mile walking and biking path along the active Norfolk Southern rail line — from Allen Road east to Hanover Street. "We think it's a natural thoroughfare," Stamos said, noting that the concept is still just that until talks can be set up with the railroad. One of the goals, Houston explained, is to link bike lanes proposed for downtown Carlisle with a rails-to-trails project that would eventually link the borough to Shippensburg and Newville. The proposal is in line with recommendations made in an urban trails and greenway study done for LRA and the proposed "road diet" in Carlisle, he said. "We are not asking for funds, just a letter of support," Stamos told the commissioners. "We just want to get our foot in the door" to have conversations with Norfolk Southern. "It's going to take some time. We have a long way to go." The board was expected to approve the support letter at its meeting today.

Kindness of Strangers

Author unknown, submitted by Brenda Barrett

There is a rail trail that runs south out of York that I have ridden several times. It is quite beautiful, leaving the city, then passing through classic Pennsylvania farmland, a railroad tunnel, woods and streams. If you keep going you get to Hanover Junction, where Lincoln stopped on his way to Gettysburg; ride further, and you will be in Maryland. Paralleling old tracks, the trail is flat, an easy ride, and the riders take it in at their leisure – nobody is racing through.

Along that trail, on the left as you go south, is a rest stop and restaurant named "Serendipity Station." Riders often stop there, and one day last fall my friend Pam and her friend finished their ride and did just that. Sitting at the outdoor tables, they saw two boys, one of them in a wheelchair, come up the side street to the trail. The boys sat there for a while, watching the bikers, then left. At home that night, the image of the quiet boy in the chair, silently watching other people ride,

led Pam from contemplation to action. She emailed the restaurant to find out if anyone there knew him; someone did, called his mother and gave her number to Pam, who called herself, a few days later. The mother said she had looked into getting a hand cranked bike for her son, but it was too expensive.

It takes a lot of money to design and assemble a bicycle that is powered by arms and not legs. The riding position is recumbent, and the crank is at shoulder level, with the chain and gearing relocated appropriately. The longest and strongest muscles in the human body are in the legs, which is why using them to pedal a bike is relatively easy. Using your upper body is much more difficult. But Pam had noticed the boy's upper body looked strong. In the following months, she collected \$3,000 from friends and family, and arranged for the assembly and delivery of a bike customized to his size and abilities.

This month, it happened. In a note to Pam, his mother wrote, "It was so cool to see him on it yesterday. He went around town a bit, but is still getting used to it so I wouldn't let him go far." She signed off, "love, peace and happiness." The boy's name is Zion. It means the promised land.

This newsletter is published 2 times a year as a service to its members and other interested persons. Opinions expressed are those of the listed authors. The editors encourage submissions reflecting on educational information for Trails. You are encouraged to submit your article for review on disc or by email to:

PRPS

**Attn: Tim Poole
2131 Sandy Drive
State College, PA 16803**

info@greendiamondtrails.com

American Trails Magazine Goes Digital

We invite you to view the Spring 2009 digital issue of the American Trails Magazine now! Click on the graphic of the Spring 2009 issue cover.

We welcome your ideas, articles, or photos for consideration for the magazine. Send us an email at trailhead@americantrails.org, or if you're interested in advertising, contact Candace Baxter via email at candace@americantrails.org or call her at (530) 547-2060.

Join American Trails to help us continue to provide our informative magazine as a service at no charge to the trails community, and to continue to be an extensive resource for you. Thank you for your support! (If you join American Trails and don't have internet access, we will have a limited number of hard copies available for our members.)

BTW ~ Visit the world's largest online resource for planning, building, funding, managing, enhancing, and supporting trails and greenways AND check out our new look: www.AmericanTrails.org.

TAKE A HIKE!

After years of controversy, most municipalities along Low-Grade Line welcome walkers, cyclists and horseback riders

By JON RUTTER, Staff Writer, Lancaster Newspapers, Inc.

The former Enola Low-Grade Line in Solanco is opening — gradually — for non-motorized business. A hiker here. A birdwatcher there. People cannot legally traverse the easternmost segment of the 23-mile-long corridor, through Sadsbury Township, where officials have not yet determined what to do with the land. Riders and pedestrians have to clamber around gaps where bridges have been removed or, in the case of the Martic Forge trestle, closed pending refurbishing. But, over much of the line, as long as they aren't operating motorized vehicles, they're now welcome. And they can travel a major portion of the line, from the trestle to the Sadsbury Township line, without encountering any major obstacles.

The fate of the old rail line through Conestoga, Martic, Providence, Eden, Bart and Sadsbury townships hung in limbo for years. That changed last July, when Norfolk Southern conveyed the property to the townships for \$1 each and handed over \$1.4 million to maintain and/or demolish bridges and road crossings. Martic, Providence, Eden and Bart have since applied for and received tax-exempt status for their holdings, according to Mike Domin, principal planner with the county. In turn, said Domin and Dee Dee McGuire, Lancaster County director of property assessment, they're supposed to open, maintain and post the

land for public access. Conestoga has not applied for tax-exempt status. However, Supervisor Steve Charles said the trail there has been "pretty much open since last summer."

The chairman of the Bart Township supervisors, Calvin Keene, said the municipality has ordered signs to notify the public the land is open. Meanwhile, Manor Township is working to extend the path 5¼ miles north along the Susquehanna River, said supervisors chairman John May. Officials in Eden and Providence say they're trying to crack down on dirt-bikers and all-terrain-vehicle riders. Parts of the Enola branch have been graded and cleared of railroad ballast and vegetation. "We're far from making it what we'd like it to be," said Eden Supervisor Glenn R. Morrison. Though the township has scant money for making improvements on the trail, he said, "We're inviting everyone to use it. We want it to be used."

At the other end of the line, Manor Township officials are vigorously pursuing establishing a trail segment that runs from the Safe Harbor trestle to Turkey Hill. That corridor, which would connect to the rest of the path in Conestoga Township, is still owned by Norfolk Southern and is closed to the public. The railroad will deed over the tract when the township finalizes a project to fence it from the active parallel rail line, according to May, the supervisor.

The state Department of Conservation and Natural Resources has given the township a matching \$250,000 acquisition grant, but is requiring the township to build the fence, May said. He estimated the fence cost at \$300,000.

Rettew Associates is designing the project and also helping the township determine how to proceed with the Safe Harbor trestle, May said. A trail steering committee consisting of members from the township, LCC and the Lancaster County Parks, among others, will be formed at the supervisors meeting April 6, May said. "We're moving along," May said. He conceded he might be overly optimistic, but said, "I'm still hoping we can start construction this year."

Special Thanks

This newsletter and the trail training provided by PRPS is funded by a grant from the Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources with the support of the Park Resource Branch of PRPS.



LARA acquires Montandon to Mifflinburg Rail Line for Trail Development

The Lewisburg Area Recreation Authority (LARA) is working to improve connectivity in the Middle Susquehanna Greenway Region by creating a 11.8 miles rail trail. LARA has acquired a rail line right-of-way stretching from Montandon through Lewisburg to Mifflinburg and plans to convert it to a trail for use by walkers, joggers, bikers and cross-country skiers. "We are excited about the recreational opportunities this will open up," said Trey Casimir, LARA's board chairman. "We have seen increasing competition between cars and bikers, joggers and walkers along our roadways.

This trail will give people a safe and attractive place to exercise their legs and enjoy the outdoors." "I see this trail helping to deliver walkers and bikers to key destinations such as the Lewisburg farmers market and growers market, school district buildings and playing fields in Lewisburg and Mifflinburg, the Union County Public Library as well as public pools and parks in both boroughs," said Casimir. "In the townships, it should give those who use bikes as a primary form of transportation a safer

place to ride. In the boroughs, I believe it will encourage some people to leave the car at home for short errands. Finally, a variety of businesses stand to benefit from the increase in foot traffic."

LARA's acquisition of the rail line was made possible in part by a \$150,000 grant from the PA Department of Conservation and Natural Resources, which was part of Union County's allotment from the state's Growing Greener II initiative. Union County Commissioner John Showers pointed out that "In our county comprehensive planning meetings, citizens in every party of Union County have been telling us that they see value in trails of this kind. Rail trails in other Pennsylvania counties have proven to be worthy building blocks of economic development, boosting tourism and bolstering local property values by enhancing quality of life.



The Montandon to Mifflinburg rail line crosses the Susquehanna West

With the acquisition complete, the next phases are planning, design and construction, which will be costly and time consuming. "We plan to seek public input throughout all phases of this project," Casimir said. "People interested in the project are encouraged to come out to our public information meetings." Casimir acknowledged that the rail line has a rich history, adding that LARA plans to help preserve that history by erecting interpretive panels and kiosks along the trail itself. For more information contact LARA at (570) 523-1743.

Progress Flowing on Water Trails

American Trails has published several documents on the PA Water Trails program on its national training and technical assistance web site. <http://www.americantrails.org/resources/water/PAwaterpartners.html>

Sharing Forum – PEC has set up a Yahoo group for sharing ideas, projects, files, etc. One of the things that we heard at the Water Trails Working Session was a strong desire for a forum to share ideas. PEC has established a Yahoo Group called PAWaterTrails to serve this purpose. Please sign up and invite others to join if you know of anyone who may want to participate. The link is <http://groups.yahoo.com/group/PAWaterTrails/>. This is the place to share ideas, ask questions and post your success stories. The site is already loaded with some links and documents.

2008 STATE TRAIL WORKER AWARD WINNERS

PENNSYLVANIA: Jim Holden

Jim Holden is the President of the Allegheny Valley Trails Association, an all volunteer, non-profit organization, whose mission is: "the acquisition of abandoned railways in the Allegheny River watershed and their rehabilitation into multipurpose, non-motorized recreational trails." Jim has been involved in the AVTA as a volunteer since its founding in 1990. In that time, he has administered about \$7 Million of grants for trail acquisition and construction, which has resulted in acquisition of 55 miles and construction of 46 miles of the Allegheny River Trail and the adjacent Sandy Creek Trail.

Jim personally helps to maintain the trails and keep the corridors mowed. Using creativity, vision, and comradery, Jim has what it takes to plan, acquire, build, maintain and promote trails and partnerships in his region. Jim is also the President of the newly-formed Erie to Pittsburgh Trail Alliance, which is working to advocate and promote the completion of a mega-greenway system of over 200 miles of linking trails. Over the years, Jim has successfully engaged a multitude of partners, including the NPS Rivers & Trails Program, who assisted with the development of a Trail Feasibility Study in the 1980's, Trail Town

public workshops in 2006, and creation of the Erie to Pittsburgh Trail Alliance in 2007. Jim truly has a big vision, and is making the vision a reality, mile by mile.



Help Save the Recreational Trails Program!

Help ensure the Recreational Trails Program (RTP) is included in the authorization of the next multi-year surface transportation bill. We have been told that nothing should be taken for granted, and that we must demonstrate success and broad constituency during this time of great pressure on gas tax receipts. As we all know, the RTP has benefited every type of trail, every state, and virtually every community across the country. But in this stressed economic time, we fear an uphill challenge to get the additional funding so needed to grow this critical program.

We need Champions!

The Coalition for Recreational Trails (CRT) is looking for champions in Congress to support the Recreational Trails Program and to ensure it is included, along with increased funding, in the next authorization! Please let us know if you have a leader in mind.

We can't afford for the RTP to be thought of as a non-essential program. One of the best things you can do to bring attention to trails, and their many benefits, is to hold a National Trails Day event on June 2nd and get your Congress members out on your Recreational Trails Program-funded trails. You'll want to make sure they get a lot of press and recognition for supporting this program!

The Coalition for Recreational Trails (CRT) needs your help!

Visit the American Trails website to learn more about CRT's efforts to bring attention to the RTP. CRT has prepared an information sheet and sign-on letter to be sent to the United States Senate and U.S. House of Representatives on April 17th and is asking allied organizations, agencies, and businesses across the country to sign on to it.

A support form can be downloaded from our website. You can either fill out the form and fax it directly to Cathy Ahern, American Recreation Coalition, or let me know, as I am keeping a running list of allied supporters to turn in to her. (If you can't get approval to sign-on this week, please send in your form when you can, as we expect additional letters to go out in the future.) We hope your organization can join this effort. Please help spread the word through your networks.

GET OUTSIDE, GET ACTIVE, GET GOING WITH FREE PASSPORT TO OUTDOOR FITNESS & FUN!

Are you looking for ways to get your recommended 30 minutes of daily activity? Perhaps you are an employer that is working to improve the health and wellness of your employees? An outdoor enthusiast; a hiker, biker, birder or boater who wants to reconnect with a former passion or start a new one? Planning a summer vacation, but gas prices making it hard? Maybe you're a grandparent who regularly entertains grandchildren? A parent who is searching for new ways to get your kids outside and active this summer? The Luzerne County Keystone Active Zone Passport program may be just what you need to turn some of that "screen time" into "green time" for the whole family.

The Luzerne County Keystone Active Zone (KAZ) Passport is a free guide that encourages people of all ages and abilities, to get outside and active using close-to-home state and county parks, trails and free events during the summer. The guide lists 24 "passport stops"; all local parks, trails and outdoor events that are within a 10 to 60 minute drive of anywhere in Luzerne

County. The passport provides the contact information for each stop so participants can research the stops in advance for specific information and directions.

To participate, obtain a passport by registering on the Steps' website: www.stepstohealthierluzernecounty.org or if one does not have internet access, by using your local library's computer, or by calling Steps, 570-408-1630 between 10:00 am and 3:00 pm Monday thru Friday. Then use the passport to visit as many stops as desired; find the answer to each stop's scavenger hunt question listed on the passport; then revisit the Steps website or call to log your answers. Participants receive a stamp for each stop visited and are automatically entered to win great prizes. The more stops visited, the greater the chances of winning prizes such as kayak tours on the Susquehanna; Dance, Dance Revolution games, bicycle gift certificates, a free stay at Split Rock Resort and Indoor Waterpark, and many more.

In addition, for every 5 stops visited and successfully logged,

participants will also earn other great incentives.

In addition to the promise of free fun and great prizes there are lots of reasons to get out and get moving with the KAZ Passport program. The program's three coordinating organizations: the Wyoming Valley Wellness Trails Partnership, the Greater Hazleton Rails to Trails and Steps To A Healthier PA Luzerne County along with a coalition of other organizations, parks and companies comprising the KAZ Planning Team; want everyone, young and old, to get moving and active for their health, now and in the future.

The passport and other information; such as how a company, school or organization can incorporate the program into their wellness efforts, is available on the Steps website: www.stepstohealthierluzernecounty.org or by calling Steps at 570-408-1630 between 10:00 am and 3:00 pm Monday thru Friday. The program will end on Labor Day, and prizes will be awarded the following week.

Inaugural PA Wilds Trails Workshop a Success

Saturday, May 30 saw over 55 trail enthusiasts from around the Pennsylvania Wilds region converge on Penn State Dubois for the first ever PA Wilds Trails Workshop. U.S. Congressman Glenn Thompson kicked off the event with a very personal message about his connection to the outdoors. Attendees then heard a dual message about how to build trails, trail organizations, and an interconnected network of trails for the region, as well as the benefits to communities and businesses from this endeavor. DCNR was on hand to collect additional mapping data and to tease us with another glimpse of the forthcoming trails web site. Several participants concluded the day with a bike ride on the nearby Clarion-Little Toby Creek Rail-Trail. For more information about the overall PA Wilds program, please visit the DCNR web site.

Maintenance Column

In the last issue of "Trails to You", we initiated a regular column on maintenance. We started by tackling the oft-asked question of "what does maintenance cost"? Recent and credible state and national studies have consistently reported annual maintenance costs in the range of \$1500-2500 per mile. At least one study has shown that this number drops considerably – to around \$700 per mile – when substantially all volunteer labor is used. With the average trail coming in at around 20 miles in length, this is still somewhere between \$15,000 to upwards of \$50,000 that must be spent on maintenance for the average multi-use trail. As you might have guessed, finding those funds will be the topic of the two maintenance columns that we will run in 2009.

Let's begin by saying where maintenance funding does NOT come from. Federal and state programs like Transportation Enhancements and C2P2 that have funded the lion's share of trail development over the past two decades do not typically cover maintenance. DCNR funds have on occasion been used for capital projects on already-developed trails, such as resurfacing or major storm repair. DCNR-administered "Rec Trails" funds have also been used toward the purchase of maintenance equipment. Such activities may fall under some definitions of maintenance. The bottom line, however, is that day-to-day operational activities – mowing the grass, emptying trash cans, cleaning rest rooms – are not covered by any of these programs, and there is no indication that this is likely to change any time soon.

With federal and state agencies out of the picture, the next rung on the ladder would be counties. Trail maintenance responsibility is most directly correlated with trail ownership and development – if you own the property and/or build the trail, you are the one with the investment that needs to be protected through maintenance. While PA counties have a spotty record at best in this area, there are a handful that have demonstrated an exemplary commitment to trail ownership, development, and maintenance. A few of those will be highlighted here, and should be held up as models when discussing a possible role for your own counties.

Westmoreland County is a founder of the Regional Trail Corporation (RTC) in southwest PA. The county helps to coordinate trail development and maintenance activities with the RTC, its member chapters, and municipal governments. The County indirectly supports trail maintenance by providing staff resources for this coordination and through annual financial support of the RTC.

Like Westmoreland, Somerset County contains a portion of the Great Allegheny Passage. Somerset and York Counties provide trail support using the hotel tax. Somerset funds approximately \$2,000 per mile of its 42-mile trail, which includes a trail manager, maintenance building and equipment, and contracted services. In York County, the hotel tax provides \$50,000 annually toward trail development activities such as planning, acquisition, and feasibility studies. Maintenance of the County's main trail is provided by the parks department through the general fund.

General fund expenditures for trail maintenance are also made in Indiana, Lancaster, and Montgomery Counties through their parks and recreation departments. These counties recognize and promote trails as important amenities for their residents as well as destinations for visitors. Based on a review of readily available budget information, these counties spend a small fraction (less than two percent) of their budgets on parks and recreation. While more specific breakdowns are generally not available, it can be assumed that trail maintenance would, in turn, be a small fraction of the parks and recreation budget.

In considering a role for your county, keep in mind:

- There are many roles for a county to play, including owning the corridor, spearheading development, or funding maintenance.
- Maintenance can be funded as a tiny fraction of the general fund budget or through the hotel tax or some other dedicated stream.
- A parks and recreation department is not necessary – counties use a variety of departments to handle trail activities including planning (Somerset) and public works (Westmoreland).
- The county judicial system can be especially helpful in providing labor such as inmates, work release, probationers, and community service.
- Not just urban counties support trails. In fact, the support of rural counties is even more critical, since rural municipalities are less likely to be able to conduct trail projects on their own.

continued on page 13

For more information on some of the trails mentioned on page 12:

County	Web Site (normally includes contacts)
Indiana	http://www.indianacountyparks.org/index.html
Lancaster	http://www.co.lancaster.pa.us/parks/site/default.asp
Luzerne	http://www.luzernecounty.org/county/departments_agencies/recreation
Montgomery	http://phs.montcopa.org/phs/site/default.asp
Somerset	http://www.co.somerset.pa.us/
Westmoreland	http://www.co.westmoreland.pa.us/parks/site/default.asp
York	http://www.yorkcountyparks.org/ and http://www.yorkcountytrails.org/

Groundbreaking Ceremony Marks Construction on Scranton Riverwalk

The Lackawanna Heritage Valley Authority conducted a groundbreaking ceremony for the Scranton Riverwalk on Friday, April 24, 2009.

The Scranton Riverwalk will extend one mile from West Olive Street along the Lackawanna River to North Seventh Avenue, Scranton. A spur trail will connect the Riverwalk to Scranton High School. The spur trail will provide a safe walking route for students to and from school and their neighborhoods. The Riverwalk is the gateway to the forty-mile Lackawanna River Heritage Trail (LRHT), a multi-purpose recreational trail along the Lackawanna River from Forest City to Pittston.

The Scranton Riverwalk is a key element in the Lackawanna River Heritage Trail system. It will connect the existing CNJ Trail in South Scranton to the Scranton Levee Trail. The Levee Trail will begin at West Olive Street and continue for three



miles to Parker Street in Dickson City. The Scranton Levee Trail is currently under development by the Army Corps of Engineers with anticipated completion in late 2009.

The Riverwalk will restore and preserve the river corridor, and it also will provide a catalyst for urban development and a revitalization of Scranton's downtown. The Riverwalk will have convenient public access and will connect to Scranton High School, Scranton's downtown commercial and cultural district, Steamtown National Historic Site, the Electric City Trolley Museum,

the State Office Building, the Mall at Steamtown, and The Commonwealth Medical College. The project will provide an attractive and enjoyable recreational green space area for residents, the business community, and visitors to Scranton.

The Scranton Riverwalk has been

funded by the Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources, the Pennsylvania Department of Transportation, and the National Park Service. Senator Robert J. Mellow and the Lackawanna County Commissioners were instrumental in obtaining state funding for this project.

For more information, visit www.lhva.org.

2009 PA Bike Summit



PA Bikes & Walks organized a successful PA Bike Summit on May 5 in Harrisburg. Nearly 100 Pennsylvanians from across rallied at the State Capitol Building to speak to legislators

about supporting “safe passing legislation” and Safe Routes to Schools. The event was the first gathering of what participants hope is an annual event. The Harrisburg Bicycle Club jumped in to volunteer and to make sure bicyclists were welcome, safe, and comfortable in their host city. The Capitol Police and the Harrisburg City Police worked together to provide an escort from the Farm Show Complex to the Capitol Stairs where bicyclists

assembled around their elected officials to hear them address the issues most important to them. Fuji Advanced Sports generously provided bicycles for riders who traveled from the farthest locations in PA. Company representatives joined ralliers to gain recognition for the bicycle industry and their economic benefits to our state.

State Representative Dave Kessler lead the event with a reading of the Governor’s Pennsylvania Bike Month Proclamation and presentation of the PA House Bike Month Resolution. Senator O’Pake’s office also provided a PA Senate Bike Month Resolution. Jointly, these documents recognize May 2009 as Bike Month, May 11-15 as Bike Week, and May 15 as Bike to Work Day.

Representative Ron Miller introduced HB1110 (Safe Passing) on March 25 with 37 co-sponsors and HB1109 (Harassment), explaining the importance of shared roads for all

modes of transportation. Senator Mike Folmer also spoke of SB776 introduced on April 18 with 14 co-sponsors.

HB 1110 and SB 776 would protect bicyclists in two important ways:

- Require motor vehicles to pass cyclists with a minimum of 4 feet, and
- Protect cyclists from a “right hook” where a motorist overtakes a bicyclist and then cuts them off by making an improper right turn into the bicyclist’s direction of travel.

Motorists misjudging the space required to pass a bicyclist and motorists turning into the path of an approaching bicyclist are two of the most common causes of bicycle crashes, accounting for 8-12% of all bicycle crashes.

For more information, please visit <http://www.livablestreets.com/projects/pabikewalk/project-home>.

ANNOUNCING THE TRAIL TOWN OUTREACH CORPS

The Trail Town Outreach Program, a three-year partnership between The Progress Fund’s Trail Town Program and the Student Conservation Association, is now underway. The five person Outreach Corps arrived in January, and will work in the Trail Towns to serve as a hands-on force for economic revitalization. The corps will help to identify economic development, conservation, and restoration opportunities in the towns and expand the work of the Trail Town Program.

The Trail Town Outreach Corps includes project leader Elisa Mayes (Asheville, NC), Robin Hale (Raleigh, NC), Tim Padalino (Franklin, PA), Bryan Ward (Escondido, CA), and Mariah Wyman (Manchester, NH). Team members bring experience in urban design, community agriculture, energy assessments, and educational outreach. Initial program activities have included participation in the Great Allegheny Passage Shuttling and Trip Packaging Summit, a sustainable living training, and town visits to West Newton, Ohio, and Confluence.

The Outreach Corps is based in Connellsville and can be seen walking (or biking in nice weather!) to and from their shared office space with the Connellsville Redevelopment Authority at 124 W. Crawford Ave. Contact the Outreach Corps by email at trailtown@thesca.org or phone at (724) 603-3151. This partnership has been made possible through funding by the Claude Worthington Benedum Foundation, The Heinz Endowments, Colcom Foundation, and the PA Department of Conservation and Natural Resources.

Grand History Trail Moves Forward

Imagine a bicycle trip through one of the nation's most historical regions: the battlefield at Gettysburg, Pa., the monuments in the nation's capital, the maritime and colonial history at Annapolis, Md., and so much more. Now imagine this trip on a 185-mile continuous loop trail, with direct connections to trains, transit, airports and existing long-distance routes along the East Coast Greenway and the Great Allegheny Passage. What you've just imagined is the very real Grand History Trail.

The York County Rail Trail Authority (YCRTA) first developed the idea of the Grand History Trail in 2005. Since then, the project has grown with funding from the Pennsylvania Department of Natural Resources (PA DCNR) and assistance from Rails-to-Trails Conservancy (RTC) and our partner, the Rivers, Trails and Conservation Assistance Program of the National Park Service (RTCA). Today, the concept continues to excite trail advocates and planners throughout the Mid-Atlantic.

As part of the next steps for the Grand History Trail, RTC staff recently presented this loop trail concept at the Maryland Bicycle Symposium, hosted by One Less Car on February 4, 2009. The trail idea received an enthusiastic response from symposium attendees, some of whom even offered to help promote the trail.

The next step is a meeting of trail stakeholders, bringing local officials, tourism representatives, trail planners and advocates together in Baltimore, Md., this April. With their involvement ending this summer, RTC will hand over materials to stakeholders to help bring the Grand History Trail one step closer to reality. RTC's contributions include an inventory of federally recognized historic resources from RTCA, a GIS dataset mapping out the trail's ultimate path and interim on-street routes, and a report outlining strategies for promoting the trail as a tourism resource. Most importantly, RTC will pass the Grand History Trail concept to trail enthusiasts,



The Baltimore & Annapolis Trail in Maryland, part of the route of the Grand History Trail (photo credit Rails-to-Trails Conservancy).

advocates and planners of the Mid-Atlantic.

For more information on the Grand History Trail, visit the project's information page, which includes a draft map of the trail's route through Washington, D.C.; Annapolis, Baltimore and Frederick in Maryland; and Gettysburg and York in Pennsylvania. As RTC completes its involvement with the project over the summer, more information on the trail will be posted online.

To learn more about the Grand History Trail, contact Kelly Pack at kellyp@railstotrails.org or call 202.974.5148.

65 ATTEND SHUTTLING & TRIP PACKAGING SUMMIT

Sixty five businesses and individuals attended the Jan. 21 Great Allegheny Passage Shuttling and Trip Packaging Summit and shared information on how to transport trail users and develop themed trip packages for visitors.

Wendy Duchene, owner of Allegheny Recumbent Tours in Confluence, said that she was "heartened by the great turnout and the connections that were no doubt made by the people there. I know that I personally connected with at least four people I had been hoping to meet, as well as others that I now hope to do business with in the upcoming season."

If you missed the summit please visit www.trailtowns.org for meeting notes and a list of participating businesses.

Pennsylvania Recreation & Park Society
2131 Sandy Drive
State College, PA 16803-2283
814-234-4272
www.prps.org



Non-profit organization
US Postage
PAID
State College, PA 16801
Permit 99

5th Annual PA Greenways & Trails Summit

“Connecting Communities Through Recreation and Heritage”

September 27-29, 2009

**Blair County Convention Center
Altoona, PA**

- Keynote addresses from national leaders in greenways, trails, and active living
Recreational outings including hiking, biking, ATV, and equestrian
- Tours and Mobile Workshops
- Educational tracks on technology; maintenance and management; community and economic development; and health, wellness and active living
- Main Line Canal Greenway Workshop
- Networking with peers, consultants, local, state, and federal government officials

Cost: \$99 for Full Summit

Registration Guide available after June 19, 2009 at www.prps.org